chose to believe the failed missile attack was purposeful, with Beijing trying to send a message that it would knock out the US carrier were it to continue on into the South China Sea. However, in the press of time, voices arguing that Washington needed to send a signal back to Beijing were dismissed. Instead, within three hours of the attempted DF-21 strike, orders came from Hawaii, originating in Washington, that the *Gerald Ford* was to hold position east of the Bashi Channel, located 100 miles north of Luzon and 120 miles south of Taiwan, which essentially formed the border between the Philippine and South China Seas. Now the strategic implications of sending US aircraft carriers into Beijing's "kill zone" were becoming clear. Washington planners were in a quandary, for the *Gerald Ford* remained within range of both DF-21D and DF-26 missiles, but officials were loath to pull the carrier farther back, for fear of being seen as abandoning the conflict; nor did they want to risk an escalation of hostilities by targeting Chinese assets not directly involved in the skirmishing. Again, it appeared that the Chinese had checked the Americans, though without knocking them off the board.

When word reached Taiwan that the *Gerald Ford* had halted, the island's president, from the mainland-leaning Kuomintang (KMT) party, announced on September 17 that Taiwan was henceforth a neutral in the conflict and would accept Chinese naval patrols of its sealanes and overflight. He further ordered the two US ships that had taken refuge there to either leave Taiwanese waters or declare they were no longer combatants and remain quarantined in port.

The Chinese Introduce Electronic Warfare

After one day on station, on September 17, the escort ships with the *Gerald Ford*, including the cruiser *Antietam* and three DDGs, continued toward the Spratlys. The PLA Strategic Support Force then began wide-scale electronic warfare measures and cyberattacks on US systems, after hesitant moves to interrupt US systems in the first week of the conflict. It succeeded in repeatedly interrupting GPS and shutting down various US computer and communications systems, including